Mummy Source

DUMMY SOURCE NEWSLETTER

The Best and Only Medical Physics Newsletter — *Issue #5*

MAN JETTISONS BABY, KEEPS BATHWATER

Varian unveils 'Accela' the first linac to sound like a ride-sharing app

No word yet if it will include surge-pricing.

The Accela (short for ACCELerator Accelerator) is a next generation linac radiotherapy platform featuring DMAT, which company representatives have described as "like VMAT, but better and more expensive". The system also includes NeoArc technology, unless users opt for the Blue Pill Package - in which case the story ends, you wake up in your bed and believe whatever you want to believe. Yes, that was a 'The Matrix' reference. (P.Watson)

We've cracked the QR code:

Download Past DS Issues Here!
Mailing list!
URLs!

thedummysource.github.io



Rub-a-dub-dub, no kid in the tub!
The li'l tyke before the 'incident'.
(L.Yurkowski & P.Watson)

First diagnostic X-ray images taken from space

Meanwhile, all us working stiffs are busting our butts down here on earth. (P.Watson)





Ultrasound smuggles drugs past blood brain barrier, Canada-US border

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COMP Cruise - Yacht Rock Playlist

Those lucky enough to have enjoyed the COMP Night-Out cruise in Vancouver this summer might have noticed the smooth, polished sounds of yacht rock playing on the PA as we toured around the harbour. Appropriate, I thought. But then, I continued thinking, what if there were a yacht rock playlist just for us medical physicists?

Med Phys Yacht Rock Bands:

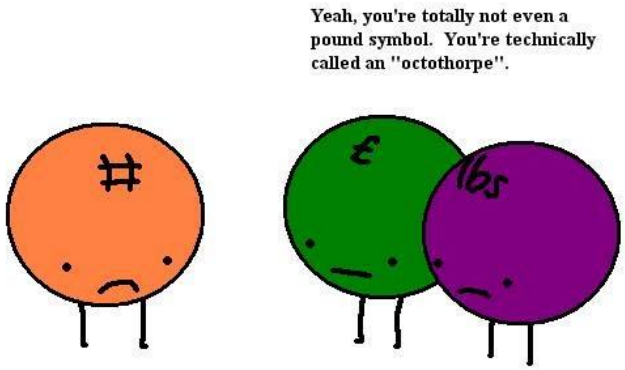
- Todd Roentgen
- Air Kerma Supply
- The X-ray Toobie Brothers
- Hall & Oates (but it's Hall the radiobiologist)
- Steely Fan beam
- Boz Scagg-Gray cavity theory
- Christopher Cross-section
- Kenny Logfiles
- Michael McDICOM
- Toto-electric effect

*Readers may have noticed the exclusion of 'The Eagles'. This is due to their low scoring on the Yachtski scale, disqualifying them from the yacht rock category and rendering them Nyacht rock. (P.Watson & K.O'Sullivan-Steben)

BREAKING NEWS!

Varian / Siemens unveiled their new high dose rate SBRT linac, Accela. This has led many to speculate that service contracts will soon be rebranded to "Rator" so that only fully subscribed customers will get the complete AccelaRator Xperience (or, "ARX").

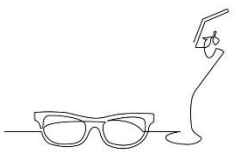
Comic Sans by Lorri Yurkowski



Punctua-shun

Overheard at a Party

"Please, Peter is my father's name. You can just call me Professor Watson."



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Contributors:
Jeb **Dexter**
Trey **Chernoff**
Lorri **Yurkowski**
Kayla **O'Sullivan-Steben**
A. **Berman**
D. **Sparkle**

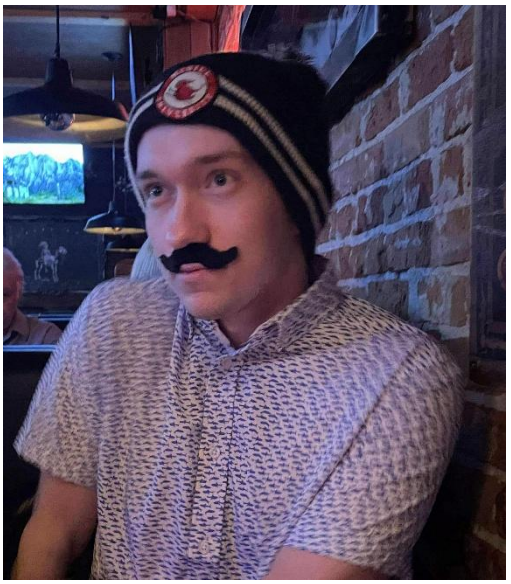
Lurk No More!
Become part of the problem and submit to Dummy Source:
dummy.source@proton.me

Pseudonyms Welcome!

Dummy of the Month!

In this feature, we wanted to showcase some of our writers and contributors who have helped to make DS the kind of high quality publication that you know and love. Our inaugural 'Dummy of the Month' is:

Trey Chernoff



About Me: I am a medical physics resident at the Jewish General Hospital in Montreal, QC. I am also an avid movie watcher and curler of granite rocks.

Where do you get your ideas from?

"Ralph's. The grocery store. Specifically, the one in Beverly Hills. In the meat section."

What are you reading?

"The third Mistborn book. Also, Calvin and Hobbes, perpetually."

What do you wish you were reading?

"The room. It would have saved me from many an awkward encounter."

When you picture a tennis ball is it yellow, or green?

"Can I say chartreuse?"

Sure. Favourite Ninja Turtle?

"Raph."

Favourite comedian?

"Norm."

Last time you laughed out loud?

"A few seconds ago, when you asked where I get my ideas from."

Last time you laughed in quiet?

"When I saw a guy down the street drop an ice cream, stare at it a moment, and let out a disappointed sigh. I felt he'd suffered enough without my decibels adding to his pain."

Last time you tried to hold a laugh in, but that just made you want to laugh harder?

"'First person to laugh loses' competitions with my siblings."

Tell me about a time you rode your bike off of a sick jump, and what you learned from the experience.

"I felt bad that the poor ramp was under the weather, but I was in a desperate hurry to get across those two rooftops. I have been racked with guilt since, especially because I didn't even land on the correct rooftop."

Any messages to our youngest DS readers?

"If I'm talking to Dummy Source readers: get a library card and use it. If I'm talking to people reading e-books on a Nintendo DS: that cannot be good for your vision."

My Boy's Wicked Smaht



Of course that's your contention. You're a first year medical physics grad student. You just got finished reading about Monte Carlo particle transport, Pedro Andreo or Dave Rogers probably. How they're the 'ground truth' in patient dose calculations. You're going to be convinced of that until next month when you get to Renner *et al*. and Valdes-Cortez *et al*. and then you're gonna be talking about the Type B uncertainties of photon cross-sections and electron stopping powers, and the differences in angular bremsstrahlung models. That's going to last until next year, you're going to be in here regurgitating Bernal *et al*., talkin' about, you know, track structure, Geant4-DNA and event-by-event electron interactions…



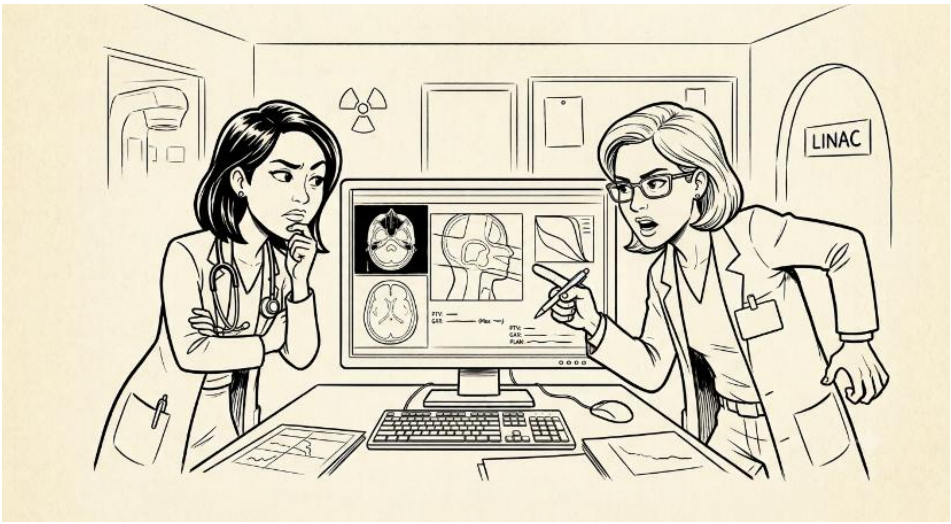
Well, as a matter of fact, I won't, because track structure codes using classical MC transport are not faithful representations–



Faithful... 'faithful representations of physical reality at these low energies, calling into question the results of MC track structure codes for sub-1 keV electron and positron transport.' You got that from Thomson and Kawrakow, 'On the Monte Carlo Simulation of Electron Transport in the sub-1 keV Energy Range', right? Yeah, I read that too. Were you going to plagiarise the whole thing for us? Do you have any thoughts of your own on this matter? (P.Watson)

Dummy Source Caption Contest - Finalists

We received a bunch of great captions from you all, dear readers! Choosing a winner was stressing me out, so I've elected to let the people decide: Vote for your favourite caption by emailing dummy.source@proton.me, the winner will be announced next issue!



"Didn't you see the sign in the kitchen? You left your gamma nuclides in the sink again!" –Bryan Van Wilgenburg

"How many times have I told you, brain scans don't work on politicians!" – Anonymous Former Student

"On the downside, we delivered a fatal dose of radiation, but on the upside I got some great data for my absorption coefficients paper." –Alex Klotz

"Alex, we all know you've been gaming the holiday gift exchange by using the wrapped presents as QA phantoms." –Jeb Dexter

"What do you think about our male colleague Kyle?" –Pete Watson

"So if you planned this, can you tell me what a GAR is? Or a Moc?" –Trey Chernoff

"My third hand finds this plan especially interesting." –Trey Chernoff

"I told you to install the linac in the room clearly labelled LINAC!" –Trey Chernoff

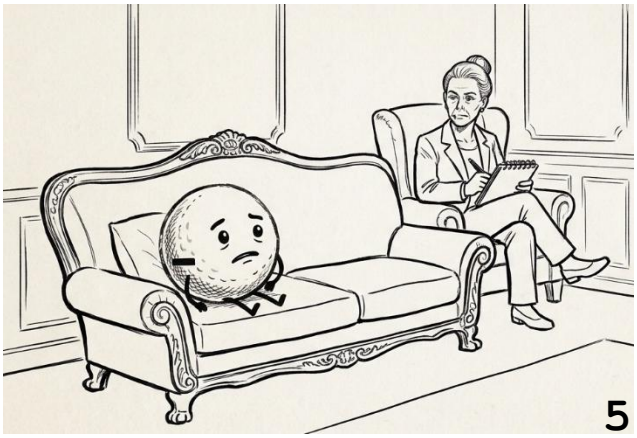
"You know what would really help me complete this plan? An alt key. If only this keyboard had one." –Trey Chernoff

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Next Issue's Caption Contest

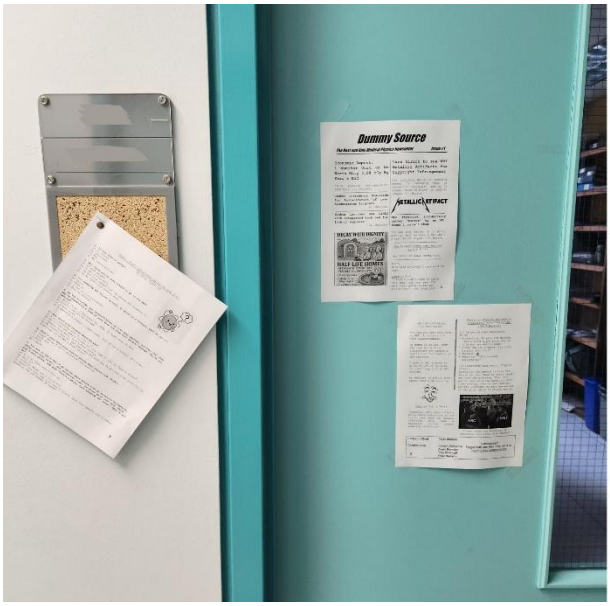
Send in your caption (along with your name) to: dummy.source@proton.me

Top submissions will be published, and a winning caption will be selected by popular vote.



Dummy Source - *Spotted in the Wild!*

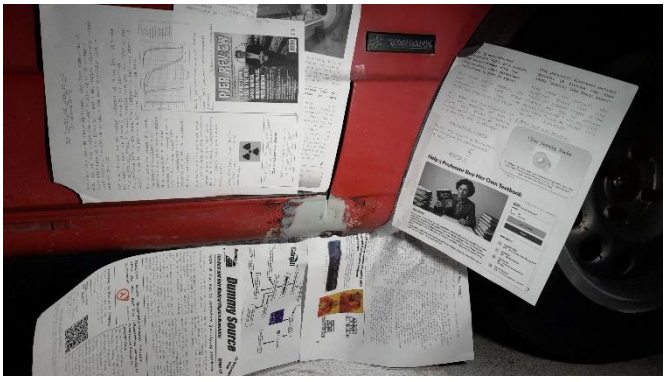
If you're like me, your go-to method for consuming DS is digitally on your computer, possibly during work hours. But I've been told that some people are actually printing hard copies, and they are turning up in some unexpected places! Here are a few cases of candid copies that have been sent in by some keen readers with cameras:



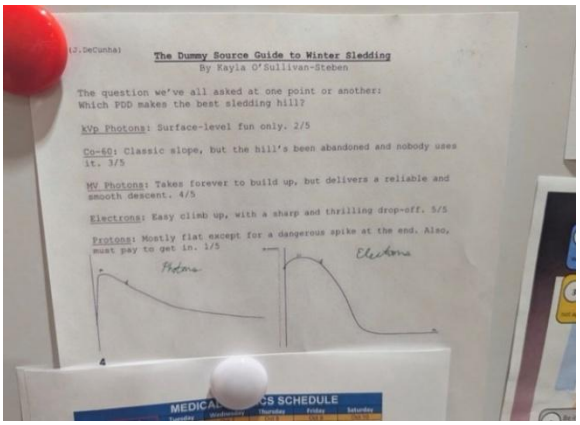
On a physics professor's door!



On the high seas!



On a classic car undergoing body work!



On the whiteboard in the clinic!

- Have you caught a glimpse of an issue of DS in a place that surprised you? Send us your photographic evidence (pics or it didn't happen, do people still say that?) to dummy.source@proton.me



Dear Dummy: An Helpful Advice Column

By Pete Watson, Trey Chernoff, and Kayla O'Sullivan-Steben



Dear Dummy, I've noticed that after conference presentations, audience questions often start with phrases like "has anyone looked at…", "a comment and a question", "interesting talk", etc. Can you help me decode what these phrases mean? -ErnestGoesToCOMP

Dear Ernest, great observation. Note that conference Q&A is highly performative act by nature, and unfolds using a specialised and passive aggressive dialect spoken fluently by all academics. This ritual evolved due to cultural norms preventing scientists from saying exactly what they're thinking, and the strong desire to begin explanations with "Actually..." Here are some translations in plain English for you:

"Interesting talk" - They didn't listen to your talk because they were too busy thinking of the question they wanted to ask.

"Has anyone looked at XYZ?" - I bet you didn't even think to investigate XYZ, I'm so clever for making that connection. Also, why didn't you cite my papers?

"A comment and a question" - I have a comment, and a question which is actually another comment because I know the answer.

Dear Dummy, following up on that, speaker responses to these types of questions often include phrases like "thank you very much for that question", "that is beyond the scope of this work", "that's a good idea", etc. What's up with that? -ErnestGoesToCOMP

Dear Ernest, two questions in a row, eh bud? I suppose we can allow that, it's kind of quiet around here. So, the Q&A ritual follows a 'call-and-response' type of pattern, where the speaker, now challenged by an offending question, gives a coded response to sound gracious and potentially save face. The phrases you've identified really mean:

"Thank you very much for the question" - I hope I think of an answer to your question before I get to the end of saying this sentence.

"That's a good idea" – This should validate your need to feel smart and let me move on to the next question. Also, your idea probably won't work and will take at least another year of research to implement, so I probably won't try it.

"That's beyond the scope of this work" - You've identified the biggest weakness of my study. But by saying this phrase, I'm hoping to shut down any further discussion on the topic.

Got a question? Ask the Dummy!

M. Bison Retires as Head of the Medical Physics Unit

Dummy Source is saddened to announce the retirement of the renowned head of the medical physics unit, Dr. Matthieu Bison. Dr. Bison's retirement celebration was held in the Prattner building, attended by the chairs of the university where several speeches were given, celebrating the career of this illustrious academic. Dr. Pablos was quoted as saying "I must admit, we were a little nervous when soon after being given tenure, Dr. Bison held 3 CNSC auditors hostage in exchange for 20 billion dollars. We thought he was mad, but our worries were quickly put to rest when Dr. Bison succeeded in attaining grant funding for the next thousand years. We do really like money." Dr. Bison is well beloved by students, who were fond of his physics demonstrations where he would create electron trails in plexiglass by shooting delta electrons from his fingertips. In the classroom, he was well known for using his psycho crusher move to demonstrate the concept of magnetic spin to first year masters students. Dr. Bison was also responsible for organizing the departmental biking team, Pax Bisonica, who have raised over 2 million for cancer research charity. In Dr. Bison's best selling textbook on radiobiology titled "My dream of creating the perfect genetic assay", he outlines how humanity can use radiation not for power or evil, but for good. His farewell speech to the department ended with a laugh as he admitted to barely remembering his first auspicious days as a professor. "The day I came to your department was the most the important day of your lives, but for me… it was a Tuesday!". His position as head will be filled by Dr. Pete Watson, who admitted in his speech that he has some very large, magnetically levitating, boots to fill. (D.Sparkle)





The fives stages of Dummy Source: (P.Watson)

1) What is Dummy Source? 2) Get me Dummy Source!
3) Get me a Dummy Source-type. 4) Get me a young Dummy Source.
5) What is Dummy Source?

Comic Sans by Lorri Yurkowski

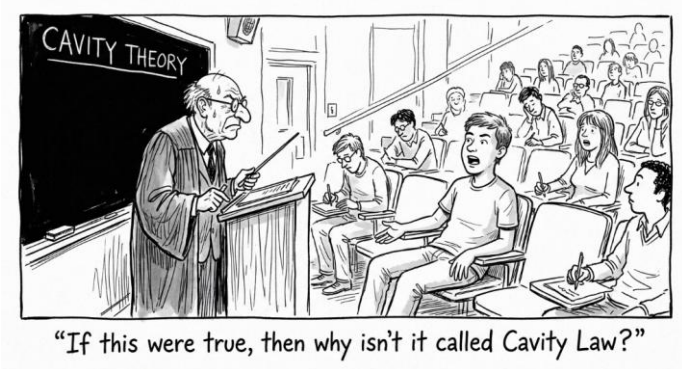


Octopus Hallowe'en



Derivative Sillies by Pete Watson





On this day in 1964:

To capitalize on the Easy-Bake Oven craze, and to partially recoup development costs from the Transit satellite navigation system, engineers at Johns Hopkins Applied Physics Laboratory released a children's baking toy operating on surplus nuclear fuel.

Containing about a half pound of plutonium dioxide fuel pellets, the "Space Age Oven" was embodied as a small, stylized satellite. Unable to be priced competitively, the toy nonetheless sold well, as the Plutonium-238 source reliably outperformed the Easy-Bake oven's 100W cooking bulb.

Sales were further bolstered by the appealing Atomic Age packaging and an included recipe for bite-sized brownies called 'Bake'erels.

Space Age Ovens still exist in the hands of devoted collectors, despite a source half life of only 88 years. Thanks to learned fans of the original toy, recipes adjusting for decay can be readily found online.

When later asked how this 'oven of the future' was at all safe for public use, project lead Dr. Richard Kershner was fond of making the joke that the ovens operated in a legal "Gray" area. (J.Dexter)

SPOOKY DS



I wanted to make a joke about the company whose mascot is an Italian plumber that wears red and blue overalls. More specifically, I wanted write a spooky story about a haunted version of their successful dual-screen handheld gaming console from the mid-2000s. However, this company is also notorious for filing frivolous copyright claims. Being the subject of such a claim is more spooky than anything I could think up here, so the creation of said spooky story has been left as an exercise for the reader. (T.Chernoff)

Dummy Sounds presents: Waveguide Wonderland

The holiday album that medical physicists didn't ask for!

This Christmas, gather the family around the linear accelerator and celebrate the season with L. Ectron Hubbard's long-awaited collection of festive favourites. Who can forget holiday tracks like:

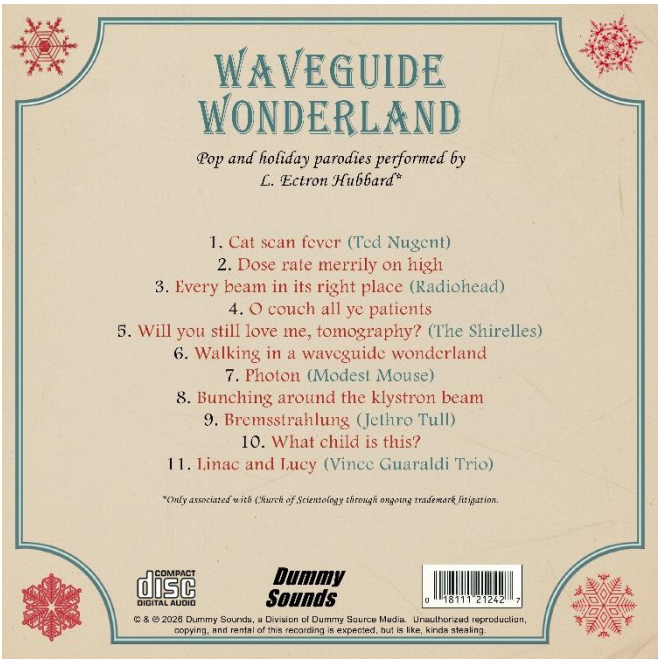
- Every Beam in its Right Place
- Linac and Lucy
- Dose Rate Merrily On High
- Bunching Around the Klystron Beam

Critics are calling it "The second-most regrettable purchase I've made all year, after barrel jeans."

Available wherever you get your novelty medical physics albums.

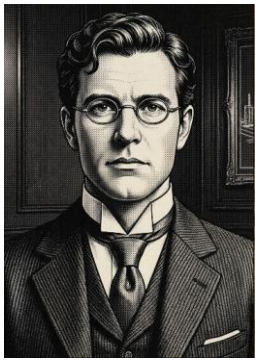
(J.Dexter & P.Watson)





Yet more from the ongoing QA Tracker Saga…

An Open Letter to the Medical Physics Community from J.M. Rappaport



Esteemed Stakeholders,

For over a year now, I have observed with morbid fascination the ongoing dispute between Drs. H.R. Roberts and R.F. Venables. Truly, I find their disagreement inspiring. It is like watching two men argue over whose steam locomotive has the most efficient shovel. What's the word I'm trying to think of here? Oh, right…: trivial.

I believe the future of clinical medical physics lies not in collecting data, but in *transcending* it. Today, my LRM (large radiation model), trained on thousands of QA reports, millions of machine parameters, and several of my favourite LinkedIn posts, can predict with 100% confidence what your measurements would have been had anyone bothered to perform them. Critics and naysayers may ask about validation, but I ask them: is it still a lie if you believe it? Is it still a dream if you don't wake up?

While Roberts and Venable debate about sub-percentage discrepancies, my AI platform successfully disrupted six industries, completed three funding rounds, and generated this very missive that you are currently reading. I ask you, dear readers, who has created more value? My flagship product, RadIQ Synergy Cloud Ultra+, offers capabilities that Roberts and Venables could not even begin to imagine, even under the influence of ketamine, ayahuasca, and unregulated peptides. Features like annual QA reports generated before the year even begins, block-chain enabled service contracts, and our proprietary Confidence Maximization Engine™ which ensures all findings are reported with the extreme confidence of a middle-aged man.

I do not question that my predecessors are not without passion for the field, and I look with admiration upon the empires that they have both respectively built. However, while they squabble and bicker in their checkers game, the world has moved on to play chess. QA is no longer just about quality assurance, but about achieving quality assumption.

In closing, I wish both gentlemen the best in their personal vendettas. Meanwhile, I invite all of you to join me on our journey into the future of medical physics. (P.Watson)

J. M. Rappaport
Founder, Chief Visionary Officer, RadIQ Technologies



Dummy's Guide to a Free Halloween

By Kayla O'Sullivan-Steben



Throwing a Halloween party on a budget this year? Fear not! Your medical physics department has everything you need for a successful spooky event.

Costumes

Masks: Mold a custom thermoplastic mask and you can be Jason, Hannibal Lecter, or Michael Myers.
Skeleton: Why buy a generic skeleton when you can acquire your own with an x-ray? Just don't forget to take off your dosimeter.
Ghost: Borrow a (preferably clean) hospital linen and cut out eye holes.
Knight: Use a lead apron for armour and a mechanical front pointer as a sword.

Snacks

Treats: Raid the techs' treat stash while doing QA. Candy, chocolate, cookies, whatever they've been gifted this week.
Anatomical Jello: Use 3D bolus molds to make fun anatomical jello shapes.
Pumpkin: Convince your boss that pumpkins make great tissue-equivalent phantoms. Scan them for science, then roast the seeds for the party.

Activities

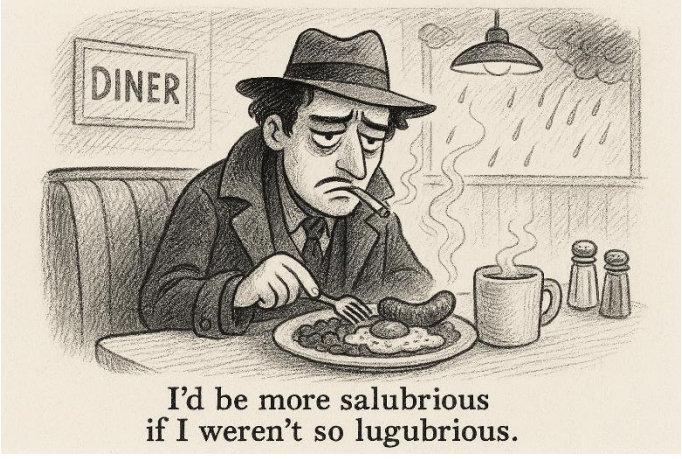
Bobbing for apples: Fill the water tank with water and load with apples. (You may want to check the last time the water reservoir was changed…)
Pin the tail on the isocentre: Using a star shot film, the closest person to the crosshairs wins (within 1 mm).
Scavenger Hunt: See who can find the most hidden LDR sources before the RSO finds out.
Guessing game: Guess how many candy corns fit in the well chamber.

Decorations

Mood lighting: Take the red bulbs from the beam-on signs for spooky ambiance. Might as well take the radiation signs while you're at it.
Halloween Art: Shape MLCs into bats, ghosts, pumpkins, and more, and deliver them on film.
Cobwebs: No need to buy fake spiderwebs from the dollar store, just use the tangled cables that the last person didn't roll up properly.
Phantoms: So many phantoms…

Have fun! And remember, the key to surviving zombies is the same as radiation: time, distance, shielding.

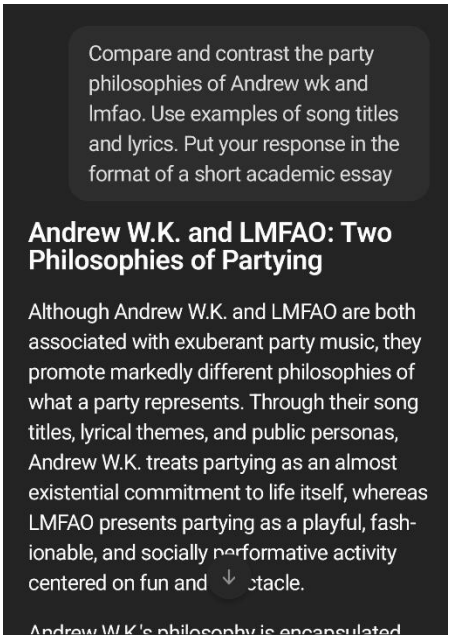
Derivative Sillies by Pete Watson



Prompt or Perish

Me: I use generative AI to be more productive at work.

Me at work:



This issue is sponsored by:

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Pilk vs Colk

On which side of history are you?



The act of adding milk to cola has existed since the invention of the bubbly brown sugar water itself, but has only recently hit the zeitgeist.

Much like the soda wars themselves, emotional brand loyalties have emerged with some consumers expressing that they would rather die of thirst than drink pilk, despite the clear evidence that pilk performs better in taste tests. Unwilling to learn from the past, one industry insider suggested that a revamped formulation of 'New Colk' is currently being developed to rival the sweeter, sharper burst of pilk.

When asked about their opinion on this topic, a random person on the street commented "that's disgusting" and "why in the good heck would I do that?" At least one person was curious what else Lindsay Lohan has been up to. (P.Watson)

"Beware that, when fighting dummies, you yourself do not become a dummy... for when you gaze long into the source. The source gazes also into you."
-Nietzsche

Sensible Chuckles
By Pete Watson

Did you hear about the X-ray tube on display at the Vatican? It has an Anode Domini.

When does a weatherboy become a weatherman? After his barometer mitzvah.

What do you call a counterfeit delta electron? A knock-off knock-on.



Nuggets of Wisdom
By Pete Watson

They say you should try to get outside more often, but radiologically that's just getting out of the radon frying pan and into the cosmic ray fire.

If you assumed someone was lying to you but they later showed themselves to be honest, would you say you were under true pretenses?

Why was Gray bragging about his theoretical cavities? And what's going on with Spencer's Attic?

If you're a damsel and you're not in distress, it's only a matter of time.

While Wilhelm's Not Looking: First X-ray Selfie Discovered

Würzburg, Germany – Researchers digging through the university archives have unearthed a radiographic plate that may be the world's first X-ray selfie. The image, believed to be that of Anna Bertha Ludwig Roentgen, appears to have been taken sometime during her husband's early X-ray experiments. Evidence that this image was taken by Anna herself includes the deliberate composition, the flattering exposure angle, and the handwritten caption "felt cute, may discard later."

(A.Berman & P.Watson)

